Teach-Back Check (Feynman Method)

Explain a topic in your own words - and let AI find the gaps you cannot see. One copy-and-paste prompt that turns any AI tool into a patient listener, questioner and checker.

Best for: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Muse and any other AI chat tool.

Use it when: You think you understand a lesson and want to prove it before a test, class presentation or viva.

The idea in one line: If you cannot explain it simply, you do not understand it yet. Teaching it back is the fastest way to find out.

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Free study note - share it with your classmates.

Why teaching back works

Reading a chapter again feels like learning, but it often is not. Your eyes recognise the words, so your brain thinks it knows them. The Feynman Method, named after physicist Richard Feynman, breaks that illusion in four simple moves:

- **1. Choose** one small topic - one concept, not a whole chapter.
- **2. Teach** it in simple words, as if to a younger student, without looking at the book.
- **3. Find the gaps** - every place you got stuck, vague or wrong is a place to re-study.
- **4. Simplify and repeat** - fix the gaps, then explain it again, shorter and clearer.

> **Your job vs the AI's job:** You do the explaining - that is where the learning happens. The AI only listens, asks questions, and points to the gaps. Never ask the AI to write the explanation for you first.

The copy-and-paste prompt

Copy this exactly, replace the brackets, press send - then type your explanation in your next message.

> Act as my teach-back checker using the Feynman Method. I will explain the topic **[YOUR TOPIC]** in my own simple words, as if teaching a younger student. Please: 1) Do not interrupt - read my full explanation first. 2) Tell me what I explained correctly, in one short list. 3) Point out every gap, mistake, or vague part, and quote my exact words for each one. 4) Ask me 3 questions that test the weak parts. 5) After I answer, give me a score out of 10 and one clear task to fix my biggest gap. Keep your language simple. Do not rewrite my explanation for me.

Tip: Speak instead of typing if your app allows voice input. Explaining out loud exposes gaps even faster than writing.

Worked example: photosynthesis

A student explains: "Photosynthesis is when plants make food. They take sunlight and water and make sugar. It happens in the leaves. Oxygen also comes out."

What the AI checks	What it finds
Correct	Plants make their own food (sugar); sunlight and water are needed; it happens mainly in leaves; oxygen is released.
Gap 1	Carbon dioxide is missing - plants take it from the air, and it provides the carbon for the sugar.
Gap 2	"Take sunlight" is vague - chlorophyll, the green pigment in leaves, absorbs light energy.
Gap 3	No word equation. The full idea is: carbon dioxide + water, using light energy, gives glucose + oxygen.

Sample follow-up questions from the AI: Where does the carbon in the sugar come from? Which part of the leaf absorbs sunlight, and why are most leaves green? If a plant is kept in the dark for two days, what changes - and why?

> **Notice the pattern:** the first explanation sounded fine. The check found three real gaps in under a minute - gaps that would have cost marks in an exam.

Try it yourself - in 5 minutes

- Pick one topic from today's lesson. Set a timer for 2 minutes and explain it without opening your book.
- Paste the prompt, send your explanation, and read the gap list honestly - do not argue with it, check it against your book.
- Re-study only the gaps, then teach it back once more. Stop when you can explain it simply, completely, and without hesitation.

> **Use AI honestly:** The teach-back must be yours - your words, your mistakes. Copying an AI-written explanation teaches you nothing and, in homework or exams, is cheating. AI can also make mistakes, so confirm every correction in your textbook or with your teacher.

More free notes: AI Prompt Shortcuts for Students - Shah Fahad's notes library.